

leanne

Test 1, 2, 1, 2, 3, 1, 2, 3, 4. Okay, we have everything. Travel Radio Australia and this month I'm chatting to the Honourable Leanne Enoch MP and here in Queensland, she's the member for Algeester, yes, and she's the Shadow Minister for Closing the Gap and Reconciliation, Shadow Minister for Seniors and Disability Services, Shadow Minister for Integrity and most importantly, Shadow Minister for the Arts in Queensland. Now, Leanne, the arts in Queensland is so important to the community and there's such a thriving arts scene here.

Yeah, there absolutely is and it is going from strength to strength and if you look particularly in the Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander space, the arts centres across Queensland have been supported by previous Labor governments and now what we're seeing is great artists coming through the system and now on the global stage. It's wonderful and I was just last recently at the Blues on Broadbeach, which is such a brilliant festival and tell us about some of the other festivals that people can come and visit. They're all over the place.

Oh, there's an incredible array of festivals across Queensland, everything from the Northern Australian Festival in Townsville through to the Cairns Indigenous Art Fair, which is over a few days in July, I think it's coming up soon, and through to the Brisbane Festival, which is the month of September, which culminates in this massive light show and firework display, which we call River Fire, which is all over the river, which is amazing. So there are multiple festivals across Queensland. There's something to do every week if you turn up here.

And there's sea fire on the Gold Coast coming up too. That's incredible too. Oh, yeah, absolutely.

You know, if you're looking for a light show, I mean, we've had these massive drone displays as well that have been so successful and lots of families turning out on the sides of rivers and on the Broadbeach to see these incredible displays, you know, using that technology that's a little bit more, I guess, you know, friendly to the environment as well. Yes, that's great. And the thing is, since Expo 88, that Brisbane precinct, the entertainment precinct has really come on hugely, hasn't it? Oh, absolutely.

Queens Wharf development, which is just open with some more pedestrian bridges across the river to link that whole cultural precinct where our Queensland Performing Arts Centre is. We're just finalising the build there for the new performing arts venue, which will see the Queensland Performing Arts Centre now will be the biggest in Australia in terms of the complex once that new theatre comes on board. So to have that connected to the other side of the river where Queens Wharf development is, you've just seen this whole city really growing up in a way where arts and culture is front and centre.

Oh, yes. Brisbane has become the centre of the artistic scene in Australia, one of the really, really major hubs. And tell us a bit about your background, Leanne.

We're speaking with Leanne Enoch MP, the Shadow Minister for the Arts in Queensland, and you were the actual Minister for the Arts here. Yeah, I was. In fact, I understand the longest serving arts minister in Queensland's history.

But my background is I'm a Quandamooka woman, so originally from a small island off Brisbane known in its English form as North Stradbroke Island. We call it Mindurabah in our language. And when I was elected in 2015, I was the first Aboriginal woman ever elected to the Queensland Parliament, and I became a minister straight away and was the first First Nations person ever to be a minister in any cabinet in Queensland.

So a lot of history that's come along with me, which, you know, I don't take for granted, but it does open up doors for big conversations about who we are as a state, who we want to be as we go forward. And, of course, arts and culture absolutely pops up in the middle of all of that and is a great vehicle for telling that story of who we are as Queenslanders. And, of course, when the people come here from overseas to Queensland and Australia, they're so fascinated with the Aboriginal culture and the Aboriginal art in particular.

And I've had a bit of experience along these lines helping them to film their galleries and things. The art is truly tremendous. Well, it's tremendous because it is reflecting ancient and contemporary story, and that's a real human connection.

When you see this art, something happens to your psyche almost, or to your soul when you see it. It's like, oh, it's connecting to something that's much more ancient than me, that's bigger than me. And I think that's why the success of it has been so amazing across the world.

And I had a bit of experience with this because when I was working in New South Wales as a 19-year-old radio announcer, I actually went out with some of the Aboriginal trackers one night to find a ram out in the middle of nowhere on a 2,000-acre farm I was living on. And that experience of just being out there in the wilderness with a billion stars, it's just fantastic, isn't it? Because the Aboriginal people know exactly where they are at all times. And people can't understand that, with a state so huge as Queensland, that the Aboriginal people know exactly what's going on.

Well, certainly, you know, it's a true connection to that country. And so even in Queensland, I mean, there are literally scores of countries in this landmass that we call Queensland. So each of those countries, if you like, if you look at the map of Europe, for instance, it's a continent, a landmass, but lots of different countries where there's different language, different types of foods, different dance, different art expressions, all of that.

Same thing happens in Queensland when it comes to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people. So, you know, I'm Quandamooka, but right next door is Jageraa, which is Brisbane. And then you go a little bit further and you've got Cubby Cubby.

And, you know, so lots of different country. And those people are absolutely connected to that

space through their ancestors, through their ancient connections. And so there's a knowing.

It's like being... It's like being in your own backyard of your own home. You know every part of that place. And that connection is very obvious when you're out there on the land with them.

Yes, it's wonderful. And for the next few years, you're going to be building up the arts here and hoping to get back into government in 2028. And I suppose you've got a big job to do.

And it's all very... You know, you're not looking back. It's all very positive looking forward. And as I mentioned to Cameron Dick, a lot of the programs that you put in when you were minister are now coming to fruition.

You must be very proud of that. Yeah, it is. It's lovely to see all that work.

You know, I just mentioned before the new Performing Arts venue. The new Performing Arts venue is something that we had committed, you know, \$150 million to. It was a really important piece to that big puzzle of making Brisbane and Queensland the place to be for arts and culture.

And so, you know, when that opens and we see then the Queensland Performing Arts Centre being the largest in Australia of its kind, that'll be an exciting moment for me as the former arts minister that saw that be put underway. That's great. And can you say hello in the Aboriginal language to our listeners around Australia and internationally? Yeah, well, of course, as I said, there's lots of different languages.

But in my language, the Djandai language of the Konamooka people, Yurra, Ngarrababajabaru, Wanyiyurra. So, to say hello and to say I acknowledge all of our ancestors, no matter what your culture and no matter where you come from. The Honourable Leon Enoch, the Shadow Arts Minister of Queensland, thank you very much for being on Travel Radio Australia.

You're so very welcome. And of course, I say to all of your listeners, come and experience Queensland. It is an incredible place and I guarantee you'll love being here.

Thank you. Oh, that's so wonderful.